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Section Title(S): GIFT-GIVING

Except, as $\neq$ Toma said, that it would be surprising to see a man give a present to a woman who was not related to him (and vice versa I imagine), anyone may give to anyone. Degree or kind of consanguinity or affinity, having the joking relationship or lacking it, impose no requirements or restrictions. We did hear people say, however, that the k"xau n!a of a band may feel that he should lean well to the generous side in his giving, for this position focuses a little extra attention on him and he wants whatever attention he attracts not to be envious. Someone remarked that this could keep such a man poor.

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The times of giving are determined almost entirely by the individual's convenience. The !Kung do not know their birthdays or anniversaries and have no special days of the year which they mark by giving gifts. Gifts are required by convention on only three ritual occasions. The type or quantity of the gift is not patterned, but the gift should be generous. The occasions are (1) betrothals and (2) weddings, when the parents exchange gifts and give to the young couple, and (3) the ritual of a baby's first haircut, when the *!gun!a*, the person for whom the baby is named, should give him a fine present.

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Relatives give to young people with the idea of setting them up in life. Gao Beard gave an assagai and a kaross to /Gishay [1.22], saying it was his duty to see that the boy got some things because among the boy's relatives he was the most able to do so. The boy's father, Old Gaú, was very old, he explained, and did not have many possessions. People expect to wait a long time for young people to make return gifts.

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The two rigid requirements in gift-giving are that one must not refuse a proffered gift and that one must give in return. Demi said that even if he might prefer not to be obligated to someone, he would accept and prepare to make his return gift. If a gift were to be refused, he continued, the giver would be terribly angry. He would say, "Something is very wrong here." This could involve whole groups in tensions, bad words, taking sides—even a talk might occur—just what the !Kung do not want. Demi said it does not happen: a !Kung never refuses a gift. (I thought of our Christmas giving and how one would feel if one's Christmas gift were refused.) And a !Kung does not fail to give in return. #Toma said  310 that would be "neglecting friendship." A person would know that others thought him "far-hearted" and "this would worry him."

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